

Questioning Hegel: Master-Slave Dialectic in Motion

Prof. Tamar Gendler

Directed Studies, Philosophy

Spring 2026

Hegel's account of self-consciousness in the *Phenomenology* relies on the claim that self-consciousness arises from the recognition of another self-consciousness. The master-slave dialectic puts the recognition to the test when there is an imbalanced encounter between independent and dependent consciousness. Mutual recognition fails, yet the slave, through labor, attains independence. Nevertheless, such resolution raises questions in terms of why the dialectic is unjustifiedly paused, and it is unclear why the slave's independence is attained through a mechanism other than the recognition first established.

It is not enough to assert that self-consciousness arises from the dialectic with other objects since that would make it impossible to consider self-consciousness as an object itself. In the first sentence of the *Lordship and Bondage* chapter, Hegel states, "Self-consciousness exists in and for itself when, and by the fact that, it exists only for another" (p. 111). Self-consciousness is not self-standing, it lies in the very interaction between its own existence and another's. Hegel writes, "But in point of fact self-consciousness is the reflection out of the being of the world of sense and perception, and is essentially the return from *otherness*" (p. 105). When examining any perceived object, there is some notion of that which is perceiving. It is only from external things which constitute *otherness* (anything that is not itself), that an idea of the in itself is possible. However, that self-consciousness as a mere implied subject is not an object itself, and it is still unclear how self-consciousness could become an object. Hegel points at this, saying that

“self-consciousness, by its negative relation to the object, is unable to supersede it” (p. 109). If self-consciousness is only ever that which is not an object, i.e. the “negative relation to the object”, it will never take the place of an object.

That self-consciousness arises from recognition through an external self-consciousness, comes from Hegel's dialectical negation that requires independence. Self-consciousness “exists only in being acknowledged” (p. 111). The verb acknowledged carries a sense of agency in that which is external to self-consciousness: an object does not acknowledge, another consciousness does. Hence, it is not the case that any object prompts self-consciousness as previously discussed, the object itself must be self-conscious:

But at the same time (self-consciousness) is no less absolutely *for itself*, and it is so only by superseding the object.... On account of the independence of the object, therefore, it can achieve satisfaction only when the object itself effects the negation within itself.... Since the object is in its own self negation, and in being so is at the same time independent, it is consciousness. (p. 109, *Phenomenology*)

This describes what occurs when a self-consciousness asserts itself through an object (these shall be referred to as the original self-consciousness and object). That self-consciousness is *for itself*, meaning that it acknowledges itself, marks the necessity for it to supersede (take the place) of the object. One must be able to consider one's own self-consciousness as an object. For it to be possible to supersede the object, the object itself must “effect the negation within itself”; in other words, the original object must be able to negate its own self-consciousness, turning the original self-consciousness into an object. This negation only occurs when the original object is independent, meaning that they have fully established their self-consciousness. Put as a dialogue, the original self-consciousness says to the original object ‘*you are not me*’; yet, for the original self-consciousness to become an object, the original object must reply ‘*you, too, are not me*’,

and, for such a response to be possible, the original object must be an independent self-consciousness.

Understanding the dialectic of self-consciousness, mutual recognition arises out of the need each independent self-consciousness has to assert itself through the other. Given the dialectic described above, for a self-consciousness to assert itself, it must be acknowledged through another self-consciousness. That being true for both self-consciousnesses, means that “they recognize themselves as *mutually recognizing* one another” (p. 112). If one self-consciousness spoke to the other, it would say, ‘*I recognize myself since you recognize myself by recognizing yourself through me*’. The vertiginous picture of mutual recognition is deliberate: the dialectic implies a back and forth in recognition.

The slave in the master-slave dialectic attains true independence through the dialectical reversal which transforms the slave’s initial state. The lord is initially a “pure self-consciousness” which is “the independent consciousness whose essential nature is to be for itself”, and the bondsman “whose essential nature is simply to live or to be for another”, in other words, “consciousness in the form of *thinghood*” (p. 105). The noun “thinghood” is crucial, the slave’s immediate state is that of an object whereas the master’s is that of an independent subject. Yet, when the dialectic is enacted, such states are reversed. The lord, in attempting to assert himself through the bondsman, realizes that “what now really confronts him is not an independent consciousness, but a dependent one” (p. 117). Since the recognition from another depends on the other’s independence, the lord’s self-consciousness cannot fully realize itself. What started off as an independent self-consciousness facing a dependent one collapses due to the lack of independent recognition. The same reversal occurs for the bondsman, “servitude in its consummation will really turn into the opposite of what it immediately is; as a consciousness

forced back into itself, it will withdraw into itself and be transformed into a truly independent consciousness" (p. 117). Saying that the slave withdraws into itself complicates the mechanism of the dialectic: it is not the case that the slave simply recognizes themselves fully through the master. How such independence is reached will be discussed after in the slave-work relationship; nevertheless, it is unclear why this imbalance is a stopping point: is it not the case that as soon as the slave attains truly independent consciousness, the lord is now in a position to see themselves properly through the slave?

The slave-work dialectic is what makes the slave conscious of their already attained independence through the master-slave dialectic. When it comes to the master-slave dialectic, "servitude has the lord for its essential reality; hence the *truth* for it is the independent consciousness that is *for itself*. However, servitude is not yet aware that this truth is implicit in it" (p. 117). Given the recognition described previously, one's self-consciousness relies on the self-consciousness of another. Since the lord is self-conscious, the slave reaches independent consciousness. However, the slave regards themselves as their immediate state of dependency and does not realize their own independence. Therefore, the slave-work relationship serves as one that reveals what has already been attained through the master-slave dialectic.

The slave-work relation seemingly evades the requirement of external recognition. Unlike desire, which consumes its object and leaves nothing behind, work "forms and shapes the thing" (p. 118). For instance, an apple is eaten and its status as object is rendered null, but in carving wood, the wood persists over time. When Hegel says that, "the negative relation to the object becomes its *form* and something *permanent*", the negation referenced is not the earlier negation, in which a subject asserted itself by negating an object; rather, the worker constantly negates the object in pursuit of transforming it. The work on the piece of wood transforms it,

which negates its staticity, but it does not consume it: a relative independence arises. Notice: independence for Hegel is not the absence of interaction, but participating in such an interaction without succumbing. Once such independence is granted: "the formative activity is at the same time the individuality... which now, in the work outside of it, acquires an element of permanence" (p. 118). The individuality (independence) of the slave is reflected through their work, the worker now too participates in this interaction without succumbing. However, the slave has attained full independent self-consciousness through a worked object rather than from another self-consciousness: a process entirely distinct from the master-slave dialectic. Does this not contradict the requirement that self-consciousness can only be grounded in the recognition of another self-consciousness?

Mutual recognition is not attained, yet it is still unclear in what state each self-consciousness is left in. The lord subjugates the other, in doing so, the dialectic of reversal makes it so his own self-consciousness is subjugated. Contrarily, the bondsman subjugates himself to the lord, elevating the lord's independence, and in doing so elevates himself. The result is a "recognition that is one-sided and unequal" (p. 116), where the slave, rather than the lord, attains independent self-consciousness. Yet, if it is the case that through the slave-work dynamic the slave becomes self-conscious, it is unclear what stops the master from asserting themselves since they are now being recognized through self-consciousness. Hegel has frozen the frame at the imbalance, but why the master-slave states do not continue reversing is unclear.

If the initial reversal between master-slave produces an imbalance, what stops them from exchanging states indefinitely? If the slave-work interaction is an outlet of some sort which leads to the slave's independence, does this not contradict the requirement of external acknowledgement that grounded the dialectic to begin with? And, if such independence is

asserted, why is the master-slave dialectic not revised since the slave is now self-conscious? Each question points, from a different angle, to the same difficulty: Hegel's circular argument makes it so between two selves, a change in the state of one, changes the state of the other, and it is unclear how such a dynamic is supposed to halt or be sublimated.